

Artist says he is 'only a tool'

After 18 years, Anaheim resident finishes glass carving of 'Last Supper.'

By **MIRA JANG** / The Orange County Register

ANAHEIM - Bob Goellner is happy, even eager to mix up a batch of Belgian waffles for a guest. In just five minutes, he can dish up four of the tasty treats on his antique waffle maker.

He's just as passionate, or more so, about his glass carvings, but not nearly as speedy.



The three-dimensional glass carving by Bob Goellner, right, of "The Last Supper" is 18 inches by 87 inches.

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Bob Goellner, 75

Residence: Anaheim

Hometown: Born and raised in Ohio

Occupation: Retired Marine and police officer, now glass carver

The art: Prices begin at \$300; Goellner could carve almost anything, from animals to the ocean to cars.

Business: Goellner's Carved Glass, 1326 W. Santa Ana St., Anaheim 92802; (714) 533-1525

Web site: www.goellnerscarvedglass.com

The Process

Step 1: Pick any piece of glass (mirrors, drinking glass, shower doors).

Step 2: Place a "resist," a heat-resistant rubbery coating, on the glass.

Step 3: Attach your paper sketch to the resist with an adhesive spray.

Step 4: Cut every line of the design with a sharp blade, such as an X-acto knife.

Step 5: Remove paper by sections as you outline the shape onto the resist with a pen.

Step 6: Begin removing parts of the resist to sandblast.

Step 7: Sandblast from the farthest point out and move in to create a three-dimensional design.

Step 8: Repeat each section until complete.

Source: Butch Young, professional glass carver

Goellner spent 18 years to complete a carving of Leonardo da Vinci's "The Last Supper," unveiled last week in the warehouse behind his studio.

The work, 18 inches by 87 inches, is three-dimensional, with detail down to the creases in robes and fine strands of hair.

"I just knew when I was done," said Goellner, 75, a retired Marine and Anaheim police officer. "I wanted to make changes but I was stopped. Somebody was there with me."

That somebody is God, Goellner said.

"This is truly not mine. I was only a tool," he said.

Growing up in the church, Goellner saw the "The Last Supper" many times but never thought much of it until the day he felt the urge to draw it. He said he just wanted to create something beautiful.

"I wasn't looking to do something nobody else did. I just wanted to do something pretty. It never even occurred to me that people would be interested."

After scrapping seven sketches, which he uses as guides for his carvings, Goellner was finally pleased with the eighth one, which was the most detailed and accurate.

"There is not one minute of work in here. This was all such a pleasure. I had a peace and tranquility in me the whole time I was working on it," he said.

Whenever the mood struck him Goellner would carve a finger, a wrinkle, a crease. A pupil took 10 minutes. Sometimes he would wait weeks before resuming work, sometimes months. During the last stretch, he put in full days.

That he completed the carving two days before the movie opening of "The Da Vinci Code" is pure coincidence, he said.

Butch Young, a professional glass carver and teacher with 19 years of experience, said the work is quite a feat even for the most experienced glass carver.

"It would be an absolutely daunting challenge to take on 'The Last Supper' with all the robes, faces and disappearing lines. It's difficult to carve," said Young, who says she has seen only two or three glass carvings of "The Last Supper" in the United States.

A high-quality glass carving could be worth tens of thousands of dollars, she said.

Young said most glass artists prefer working with stained glass or stencils.

"Glass carving is one of the hardest to master. A good carver is a very rare thing," she said.

Anaheim resident Mike Landreth bought two of Goellner's works a couple of years ago to place in his bathroom.

"They are very creative and warm. A great deal of affection and love is evident in his work," he said.

Since Goellner retired from the Anaheim Police Department in 1975 he has been perfecting his art, teaching himself through books and practicing on smaller pieces, such as drinking glasses. He has completed 25 major projects.

"When I do an art piece for someone, they can feel the heart that went into it," he said. "My greatest joy in life is to make people feel good."

Goellner said he isn't sure if he will sell his latest creation. He is considering lending it to museums and churches.

And he's not certain what his next project will be.

For now, he's focused on expanding his clientele, sharing his love of art and making waffles for his visitors.